

FREE HR MASTER GUIDE

Learn HR → Build Skills → Get Your First HR Job

Fresher → Specialist → Manager → Leadership

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Don't make the mistake of doing 15 random HR certificates.

For every domain:

Learn → Practice → Build a project → Fix your resume → Apply → Prepare for interviews

Your certificate proves that you studied something.

Your project proves that you can do something.

1. HR FUNDAMENTALS

Who should start here?

If you are completely new to HR, start here before choosing a specialization.

What you should learn

- HRM fundamentals
- Employee lifecycle
- Recruitment & selection
- Job analysis
- Workforce planning
- Onboarding
- Performance management
- Compensation & benefits
- Employee engagement
- L&D
- HR policies
- Basic HR metrics
- HR technology
- AI in HR

FREE TRAINING

1. Great Learning — Human Resource Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/human-resource-management>

Covers HRM, talent acquisition, employee lifecycle, performance management, compensation, engagement, workforce planning and AI in HR.

2. Great Learning — Organizational Behaviour

Available through the Great Learning free HR catalogue:

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/human-resource-management/free-courses>

Useful for understanding workplace behaviour, motivation, teams and organisational dynamics.

3. SWAYAM

<https://www.swayam.gov.in/>

Search for:

- Human Resource Management
- Organisational Behaviour
- Industrial Relations
- Strategic HRM
- Training & Development

4. NPTEL

<https://www.nptel.ac.in/>

Search HR/management courses from IITs and other institutions.

Skills to develop

Must-have

- Communication
- Excel
- Documentation
- Professional email writing
- Basic HR terminology
- Problem solving
- Interviewing
- Stakeholder management

Fresher roles

Search:

- HR Intern
- HR Trainee
- HR Executive
- HR Coordinator
- HR Associate
- People Operations Associate
- HR Generalist Trainee

Build before applying

Create a small **HR Portfolio** containing:

1. Sample onboarding checklist
2. Employee lifecycle map
3. Leave policy
4. HR SOP
5. Recruitment tracker
6. Sample employee engagement survey

Interview preparation

Be ready for:

- What are the major functions of HR?

- Explain employee lifecycle.
 - Difference between recruitment and selection.
 - What is onboarding?
 - What is performance management?
 - What is employee engagement?
 - Difference between HR Generalist and HR Specialist.
 - Why did you choose HR?
 - Which HR domain interests you?
-

2. TALENT ACQUISITION / RECRUITMENT

This is one of the easiest HR domains for a fresher to demonstrate practical capability because you can create recruitment projects even without corporate experience.

Learn

- Recruitment lifecycle
- Job descriptions
- Sourcing
- Boolean search
- LinkedIn sourcing
- Screening
- Candidate calling
- Interview coordination
- Candidate experience
- Recruitment metrics
- Offer management
- Onboarding handover

FREE TRAINING

1. Great Learning — Human Resource Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/human-resource-management>

Its current syllabus includes talent acquisition, recruitment, workforce planning and ethical recruitment.

2. Great Learning — Talent Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/talent-management>

Covers recruitment, selection, onboarding, talent pipelines, HR planning, engagement and retention.

3. SWAYAM

<https://www.swayam.gov.in/>

Search:

- Recruitment & Selection
- Human Resource Management

- Talent Management
- Organisational Behaviour

Additional skills

Learn:

- LinkedIn
- Naukri
- Boolean search
- Excel
- ATS basics
- Email writing
- Candidate calling
- Interview scheduling
- Basic recruitment analytics

Your first portfolio project

Take one imaginary position:

Example: HR Business Partner – IT company

Create:

- JD
- Candidate persona
- Boolean search string
- 20 potential candidate profiles
- Screening checklist
- Interview questions
- Recruitment tracker
- Candidate communication templates

Now you have something to discuss in an interview.

Apply for

- Talent Acquisition Intern
- Recruitment Intern
- Recruiter
- Recruitment Executive
- Talent Acquisition Associate
- Recruitment Coordinator
- IT Recruiter
- Non-IT Recruiter

Resume keywords

Use words such as:

Candidate sourcing | Screening | Boolean Search | Recruitment Coordination | Interview Scheduling | Candidate Experience | Recruitment MIS | LinkedIn Sourcing

Interview preparation

Prepare for:

Technical

- Explain recruitment lifecycle.
- What is Boolean search?

- How would you source an IT candidate?
- Difference between active and passive candidates.
- What is candidate screening?
- What recruitment metrics do you know?

Situational

"You have 10 open positions and only 3 days. What will you do?"

Your answer should demonstrate:

prioritisation → sourcing strategy → screening → stakeholder communication → tracking

Practical

You may be asked to source candidates live.

So actually practice Boolean searches before interviews.

3. HR OPERATIONS / GENERALIST

This is the domain for someone who likes **employee lifecycle + policies + documentation + multiple HR functions.**

Learn

- Joining formalities
- Employee documentation
- HRIS
- Attendance
- Leave
- Payroll coordination
- Onboarding
- Exit process
- HR letters
- Policies
- Employee records
- HR MIS
- Employee queries

FREE TRAINING

Great Learning — Human Resource Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/human-resource-management>

It currently covers employee lifecycle, onboarding, engagement, performance, compensation and HR technology.

Great Learning — People Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/people-management>

Covers communication, hiring, mentoring, people management and employee leadership.

Great Learning free HR catalogue

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/human-resource-management/free-courses>

Tools

Learn:

- Excel
- Google Sheets
- HRMS basics
- PowerPoint
- Documentation
- Email communication

Portfolio project

Create a complete:

Employee Onboarding Kit

Include:

- Joining checklist
- Document checklist
- Welcome email
- Day 1 agenda
- 30-60-90 day plan
- Probation tracker
- Exit checklist

Apply for

- HR Operations Executive
- HR Executive
- HR Coordinator
- People Operations Associate
- HR Shared Services Associate
- HR Generalist Trainee

Interview preparation

Know:

- Employee lifecycle
- Joining process
- Exit process
- Full & final settlement basics
- Leave management
- Attendance
- HR documentation
- HRIS
- Employee grievance handling
- Confidentiality

Expect:

"An employee says their salary is incorrect. What will you do?"

Don't immediately say, "I'll tell payroll."

Explain:

verify → check records → identify discrepancy → coordinate → communicate → document → close

That demonstrates HR thinking.

4. PAYROLL & COMPENSATION

If you're comfortable with **numbers, Excel and process accuracy**, this can become a strong specialization.

Learn

- CTC structure
- Gross salary
- Net salary
- Deductions
- Fixed vs variable pay
- Incentives
- Benefits
- Salary structures
- Payroll inputs
- Payroll reconciliation
- Statutory concepts
- Compensation benchmarking

FREE TRAINING

1. Great Learning — Compensation Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/compensation-management>

Covers salary structures, pay bands, incentives, benefits, compensation plans and compensation processes.

2. Great Learning — Human Resource Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/human-resource-management>

Includes compensation and benefits fundamentals.

3. Great Leap Knowledge Hub

<https://greatleap.in/webinar.html>

Provides free and paid sessions covering payroll, labour law and HR systems.

Critical skill

EXCEL.

Learn:

- XLOOKUP/VLOOKUP
- IF
- SUMIF/SUMIFS
- COUNTIF
- Pivot Tables
- Conditional Formatting
- Data validation

- Basic reconciliation

Build this project

Create a dummy payroll sheet for **20 employees**.

Include:

- Employee ID
- Basic
- HRA
- Allowances
- Gross
- Deductions
- Net salary
- Employer contributions
- CTC

Then create a **salary reconciliation sheet**.

Apply for

- Payroll Executive
- Payroll Associate
- Compensation & Benefits Associate
- HR Shared Services Associate
- Payroll Analyst
- C&B Analyst

Interview preparation

Be prepared to explain:

- CTC vs gross salary
- Gross vs net salary
- Fixed vs variable pay
- Salary structure
- Payroll inputs
- Payroll reconciliation
- Why payroll accuracy matters
- How you would handle a payroll discrepancy

For India-specific statutory compliance, study the current applicable rules separately rather than relying on an old course.

5. LEARNING & DEVELOPMENT

For people who enjoy:

training + presentations + employee development + facilitation.

Learn

- Training needs analysis
- Training design

- Learning objectives
- Instructional design
- ADDIE
- Facilitation
- Training delivery
- LMS
- Training evaluation
- Learning metrics
- Career development

FREE TRAINING

Great Learning — Human Resource Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/human-resource-management>

The course includes training and development and the ADDIE model.

SWAYAM

<https://www.swayam.gov.in/>

Search:

- Training & Development
- Learning & Development
- Organisational Behaviour
- Management

NPTEL

<https://www.nptel.ac.in/>

Search for training, organisational behaviour and management courses.

Build a project

Create a **New Manager Training Program**.

Include:

- Training need
- Learning objectives
- 4-session curriculum
- PPT outline
- Activities
- Assessment
- Feedback form
- Post-training evaluation
- Success metrics

Apply for

- L&D Intern
- Training Coordinator
- L&D Coordinator
- Learning Associate
- Training Executive
- Talent Development Associate

Interview preparation

Know:

- ADDIE
- Training needs analysis
- Learning objectives
- Kirkpatrick model
- Training evaluation
- Learning effectiveness
- LMS

Possible question:

"How would you identify whether employees actually need training?"

Answer through:

business problem → performance gap → skill gap → TNA → intervention → measurement

6. PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT

Learn

- Goal setting
- KPIs
- KRAs
- OKRs
- SMART goals
- Performance cycles
- Mid-year reviews
- Appraisals
- Feedback
- Performance improvement plans
- Rewards

FREE TRAINING

Great Learning — Performance Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/performance-management>

It covers performance planning, SMART goals, monitoring, reviewing and rewarding.

Great Learning — Human Resource Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/human-resource-management>

Build

Create a complete performance framework for a fictional company:

Employee → KRA → KPI → Weightage → Rating → Feedback → Development Plan

Apply for

- Performance Management Associate
- HR Generalist
- HR Operations Associate
- People Operations Associate

- Talent Management Associate

Interview questions

- KPI vs KRA
 - What makes a good KPI?
 - What is SMART?
 - What is a performance improvement plan?
 - How do you handle an employee disputing their rating?
 - How can HR make performance reviews more effective?
-

7. EMPLOYEE ENGAGEMENT / EMPLOYEE EXPERIENCE

Learn

- Employee engagement
- Employee experience
- Pulse surveys
- Culture
- Recognition
- Rewards
- Internal communication
- Employee listening
- Retention
- Engagement metrics

FREE TRAINING

Great Learning — Human Resource Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/human-resource-management>

Includes engagement, feedback, employee experience and retention concepts.

Great Learning — People Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/people-management>

Great Learning — Talent Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/talent-management>

Includes engagement and retention.

Portfolio project

Conduct a **dummy employee engagement survey**.

Create:

- 10–15 questions
- Survey
- Response data
- Engagement score
- Top 3 issues
- Action plan

- Communication plan

Apply for

- Employee Engagement Executive
- People Experience Associate
- Culture & Engagement Coordinator
- Employee Experience Associate
- HR Generalist

Interview preparation

Know:

- Engagement vs satisfaction
- Employee experience
- Pulse survey
- eNPS
- Recognition
- Retention
- Employee listening

Be prepared for:

"Engagement scores have fallen. What would you do?"

Don't jump straight to an event.

Talk about:

diagnosis → segmentation → root cause → intervention → measurement

8. HR ANALYTICS / PEOPLE ANALYTICS

This deserves extra attention because it is **not simply Excel + dashboards**.

Learn

HR concepts + data + analytics + storytelling.

FREE TRAINING

1. Great Learning — HR Analytics

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/hr-analytics-course>

Covers HR metrics, levels of analytics, data management, visualisation and challenges.

2. NPTEL — HR Analytics

<https://www.nptel.ac.in/courses/110107492>

The current course covers HR analytics across recruitment, training, performance and compensation, plus data visualisation using tools including Tableau and Power BI.

3. SWAYAM / NPTEL

<https://www.swayam.gov.in/>

Search HR Analytics and People Analytics courses.

Learn separately

Excel

- Pivot tables
- XLOOKUP
- SUMIFS
- COUNTIFS
- Charts
- Data cleaning

Analytics

- Attrition
- Turnover
- Time to hire
- Cost per hire
- Absenteeism
- Training effectiveness
- Engagement
- Workforce metrics

Power BI

Learn:

- Data import
- Cleaning
- Relationships
- Measures
- Dashboards
- Visualisation

Build 3 projects

Project 1: Attrition Dashboard

Project 2: Recruitment Funnel Dashboard

Project 3: Employee Engagement Dashboard

Apply for

- HR MIS Executive
- HR Reporting Analyst
- HR Analyst
- People Analytics Intern
- Workforce Analytics Associate
- HR Data Analyst

Interview preparation

Know:

- Attrition rate
- Turnover
- Time to hire
- Time to fill
- Cost per hire
- Absenteeism
- Recruitment funnel
- Descriptive vs predictive analytics

- HR MIS vs HR Analytics

You should also be able to explain:

"The dashboard shows attrition is highest among employees with 0–2 years' tenure. What would you investigate?"

That's where **analysis becomes HR analytics**.

9. TALENT MANAGEMENT

Learn

- Talent identification
- Succession planning
- Talent pipelines
- High potentials
- Career development
- Retention
- Workforce planning
- Internal mobility
- Performance
- Engagement

FREE TRAINING

Great Learning — Talent Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/talent-management>

Covers talent acquisition, HR planning, talent pipelines, engagement, retention, performance and onboarding.

Great Learning — Human Resource Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/human-resource-management>

Build

Create a:

Succession Planning Framework

For 5 fictional critical positions:

- Critical role
- Current incumbent
- Competencies
- Successor readiness
- Development gaps
- Development plan
- Risk level

Apply for

- Talent Management Associate
- Talent Development Associate

- HR Generalist
- People Development Associate
- Talent Management Intern

Interview preparation

Know:

- Talent management vs talent acquisition
- Succession planning
- HiPo
- Talent pipeline
- Internal mobility
- Retention strategy

10. EMPLOYEE RELATIONS / INDUSTRIAL RELATIONS / COMPLIANCE

This is one area where Indian labour-law knowledge matters significantly.

Learn

- Employee grievances
- Disciplinary processes
- Workplace policies
- Industrial relations
- Labour compliance
- Workplace conduct
- POSH basics
- Documentation
- Investigations
- Employee communication

FREE TRAINING / LEARNING SOURCES

SWAYAM

<https://www.swayam.gov.in/>

Search:

- Industrial Relations
- Labour Laws
- Human Resource Management
- Employment Relations

NPTEL

<https://www.nptel.ac.in/>

Search Industrial Relations / Labour-related management courses.

Great Leap Knowledge Hub

<https://greatleap.in/webinar.html>

Offers free/paid practitioner sessions around labour law, payroll and HR systems.

Important

Don't rely on an old "labour law certificate" to advise employees or companies.

Indian employment-law requirements can change. Always verify the **current applicable central/state rules and company context** before giving compliance advice.

Build

Create:

- Employee grievance SOP
- Disciplinary action workflow
- Workplace conduct policy
- POSH awareness communication
- Exit/grievance documentation checklist

Apply for

- Employee Relations Associate
- ER Executive
- HR Executive
- HR Compliance Associate
- HR Generalist
- IR Trainee

Interview preparation

Prepare for scenarios:

Employee complains of harassment.

Employee violates company policy.

Manager wants to terminate an employee immediately.

Employee raises a grievance against their manager.

The interviewer is testing whether you understand:

facts → documentation → policy → due process → confidentiality → escalation

—not whether you can quote random sections of law.

11. HR TECHNOLOGY + AI IN HR

This is where you combine HR knowledge with technology.

Learn

- HRIS
- ATS
- LMS
- HR automation
- AI-assisted recruitment
- AI-assisted HR communication
- Employee analytics
- HR chatbots

- Workflow automation
- Responsible AI
- Data privacy
- Bias

FREE TRAINING

Great Learning — AI in Human Resource Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/ai-in-human-resource-management>

Covers AI-powered recruitment, screening, candidate engagement, onboarding, L&D, performance, engagement and HR communication.

Great Learning — Human Resource Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/human-resource-management>

Includes AI and digital HR concepts.

Build

Create an:

AI-Assisted Recruitment Workflow

Example:

JD → sourcing → screening → interview scheduling → candidate communication → feedback → reporting

But show where **human review** is required.

Apply for

- HR Technology Intern
- HR Operations Associate
- HRIS Associate
- HR Automation Associate
- People Operations Associate
- HR Digital Transformation roles

Interview preparation

Know:

- What can AI automate?
- What should AI NOT decide independently?
- Bias in AI recruitment
- Data privacy
- AI-assisted sourcing
- AI-generated JDs
- AI in L&D
- HR automation

12. PEOPLE MANAGEMENT / LEADERSHIP

This isn't necessarily your first HR specialization.

It becomes increasingly important as you move toward:

HRBP → Manager → HR Leadership

FREE TRAINING

Great Learning — People Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/people-management>

Covers communication, people management, hiring, mentoring, leadership and employee engagement.

SWAYAM

<https://www.swayam.gov.in/>

Search:

- Leadership
- Organisational Behaviour
- People Management
- Management

Develop

- Communication
- Conflict resolution
- Coaching
- Influencing
- Stakeholder management
- Business understanding
- Decision making

13. HRBP / STRATEGIC HR

 **Important: HRBP should generally NOT be your first job target as a fresher.**

First build understanding of HR functions and business.

Learn

- Business acumen
- Workforce planning
- Talent strategy
- Performance
- Compensation
- Engagement
- Organisation design
- Change management
- Stakeholder management
- HR metrics
- People strategy

FREE TRAINING

Start with:

Great Learning — Human Resource Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/human-resource-management>

Then:

Performance Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/performance-management>

Talent Management

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/talent-management>

HR Analytics

<https://www.mygreatlearning.com/academy/learn-for-free/courses/hr-analytics-course>

Career route

Fresher

↓

HR Executive / TA / HR Ops

↓

HR Generalist / Specialist

↓

Senior HR / HR Manager

↓

HRBP

↓

Senior HRBP

↓

HR Leadership

Interview preparation

Don't prepare only HR questions.

Prepare **business questions**:

Revenue is growing but attrition has increased. What would you investigate?

A business head says HR is slowing hiring. How would you respond?

A team has low productivity. What would you analyse?

The organisation is restructuring. What should HR consider?

That is the shift from **HR execution** → **HR partnering**.

14. OD & CHANGE MANAGEMENT

Learn

- Organisation design

- Change management
- Culture
- Transformation
- Stakeholder mapping
- Change resistance
- Communication
- Organisational effectiveness

FREE SOURCES

SWAYAM

<https://www.swayam.gov.in/>

Search:

- Organisational Development
- Change Management
- Organisational Behaviour
- Strategic Management

NPTEL

<https://www.nptel.ac.in/>

Search management/organisation/change-related courses.

Build

Create a fictional:

Company Transformation Plan

Example:

Company moving from office-first → hybrid.

Create:

- Stakeholder map
- Impact assessment
- Communication plan
- Training plan
- Resistance matrix
- Success metrics

Apply for

As a fresher, don't search only "OD Consultant."

Look at:

- HR Transformation Intern
- HR Project Associate
- HR Generalist
- People Operations
- Change Management Analyst
- HR Consulting Analyst

THE FRESHER FORMULA

Now this is the part I REALLY want people to understand.

Don't do this:

Course → Certificate → Apply → Wait

Instead:

Step 1

Choose ONE HR domain.

Step 2

Complete 2–3 relevant free courses.

Step 3

Learn the tools required.

Step 4

Build 2 practical projects.

Step 5

Put those projects on your resume.

Step 6

Prepare domain-specific interview questions.

Step 7

Apply to 10–15 relevant roles every week.

Step 8

Track every application.

Step 9

Network with recruiters and HR professionals.

Step 10

Improve based on rejection/interview feedback.

HOW TO MAKE A FRESHER HR RESUME

Don't write:

"Hardworking MBA graduate looking for an opportunity to grow."

Almost everyone says this.

Instead:

PROFILE

HR graduate with foundational knowledge of Talent Acquisition, HR Operations and HR Analytics, with hands-on projects in recruitment tracking, employee lifecycle documentation and HR dashboards.

Then:

SKILLS

HR: Recruitment | Employee Lifecycle | Onboarding | Engagement | Performance Management

Tools: Excel | Google Sheets | PowerPoint | Power BI | HRIS/ATS basics

Analytics: HR Metrics | Attrition | Recruitment Funnel | Dashboarding

PROJECTS

Recruitment Funnel Analysis

- Created recruitment tracker for 100 fictional candidates
- Analysed source-wise conversion
- Calculated time-to-hire and selection ratios
- Built Excel dashboard

That's much stronger than:

"Completed HR Analytics course."

HOW TO APPLY FOR HR JOBS

Don't search only:

HR Fresher

Search according to your chosen domain.

Recruitment

- Recruiter
- Talent Acquisition Associate
- Recruitment Executive
- Recruitment Coordinator

HR Operations

- HR Executive
- HR Operations Associate
- People Operations Associate
- HR Coordinator

Payroll

- Payroll Executive
- Payroll Associate
- C&B Associate
- HR Shared Services

L&D

- Training Coordinator
- L&D Associate
- Learning Coordinator

Analytics

- HR MIS
- HR Reporting Analyst

- HR Analyst
- People Analytics Intern

Engagement

- Employee Engagement Associate
- People Experience Associate
- Culture & Engagement

The title changes from company to company. Search the FUNCTION, not just one job title.

YOUR LINKEDIN STRATEGY AS A FRESHER

Don't just write:

"Looking for HR opportunities."

Instead post things like:

Post 1:

"I analysed a fictional employee attrition dataset and found these 3 patterns..."

Post 2:

"I created a recruitment funnel dashboard in Excel. Here's what I learned..."

Post 3:

"I designed a 30-60-90 day onboarding plan for a fictional IT company..."

Post 4:

"5 things I learnt while building my first HR dashboard."

This gives recruiters something to evaluate.

HOW TO APPROACH RECRUITERS

Don't send:

Hi Ma'am, please give me a job.

Send a targeted message.

Example:

Hi [Name], I'm an HR fresher currently building my skills in Talent Acquisition and HR Operations. I recently completed a recruitment funnel project and have been actively learning sourcing and screening. I noticed your team is hiring for [role]. I'd be grateful if you could consider my profile for the opportunity. Sharing my resume for reference.

Short. Specific. Professional.

HR FRESHER INTERVIEW MASTER PREPARATION

You need 4 layers of preparation.

Layer 1 — HR Fundamentals

Know:

- Recruitment
- Selection
- Onboarding
- Performance
- Engagement
- Compensation
- L&D
- Employee lifecycle

Layer 2 — Your Domain

If you're applying for recruitment:

Know recruitment deeply.

If you're applying for analytics:

Know metrics + Excel + dashboards deeply.

Don't prepare every HR function equally.

Layer 3 — Your Projects

You should be able to explain every project:

Why did you build it?

What did you do?

What tools did you use?

What did you find?

What would you improve?

Layer 4 — Behavioural Questions

Prepare STAR stories for:

- Leadership
 - Conflict
 - Failure
 - Problem solving
 - Teamwork
 - Communication
 - Taking initiative
 - Handling pressure
-

THE "I HAVE NO EXPERIENCE" QUESTION

Don't say:

"I don't have experience because I'm a fresher."

Say:

"While I haven't worked in this function professionally yet, I've built practical exposure through projects where I worked on..."

Then explain your project.

Your objective is to move the conversation from:

"I have no experience."

to:

"I have relevant exposure and I'm ready to learn on the job."

90-DAY HR FRESHER PLAN

DAYS 1–30 — LEARN

Choose ONE domain.

Complete:

- 2–3 free courses
- Excel fundamentals
- Domain fundamentals
- Interview basics

Don't start five domains simultaneously.

DAYS 31–60 — BUILD

Create:

2 major projects + 1 small project

Example for HR Analytics:

1. Attrition dashboard
2. Recruitment dashboard
3. Engagement survey

Put them on:

- Resume

- LinkedIn
 - Portfolio/Google Drive
-

DAYS 61–90 — APPLY

Every week:

10–15 targeted applications

5 recruiter/networking messages

2 LinkedIn posts

2 mock interviews

1 resume improvement

Track:

Week	Applications	Interviews	Rejections	Feedback
Week 1	12	2	3	—
Week 2	15	3	5	Excel
Week 3	14	2	4	Domain knowledge

Now your job search becomes a **process**, not an emotional guessing game.

WHICH DOMAIN SHOULD YOU CHOOSE?

If you love talking to people:

Recruitment / TA

If you like variety:

HR Generalist / HR Operations

If you like numbers:

Payroll / C&B / HR Analytics

If you like teaching:

L&D

If you like employee experience:

Engagement / EX

If you like policies and problem-solving:

ER / Compliance

If you like technology:

HR Tech / AI

If you like strategy:

Talent Management → HRBP

YOUR HR CAREER MAP

FRESHER

↓

HR Intern / HR Trainee / Recruiter / HR Executive

↓

SPECIALIST OR GENERALIST

Recruitment

HR Operations

Payroll

L&D

Analytics

Engagement

ER

Talent Management

↓

SENIOR SPECIALIST / HR GENERALIST

↓

HR MANAGER

↓

HRBP / COE / HR LEAD

↓

SENIOR HRBP / FUNCTION HEAD

↓

HR LEADERSHIP

THE BIGGEST MISTAKE FRESHERS MAKE

They think:

"I need more certificates."

You usually need:

****1–3 relevant courses**

- 2 practical projects
- strong resume
- targeted applications
- interview preparation**

That's a much more useful combination than collecting 20 certificates.

FINAL CHECKLIST

Before applying for your first HR job, ask yourself:

- ☐ Have I chosen a domain?
- ☐ Have I completed at least 2 relevant courses?
- ☐ Can I explain the fundamentals without looking at notes?
- ☐ Do I know the tools used in that domain?
- ☐ Have I built at least 2 practical projects?
- ☐ Are those projects on my resume?
- ☐ Is my resume tailored to the role?
- ☐ Do I know the common interview questions?
- ☐ Can I explain my projects confidently?
- ☐ Have I prepared STAR examples?
- ☐ Am I applying using multiple relevant job titles?
- ☐ Am I networking with recruiters?
- ☐ Am I tracking my applications?

If you can tick most of these, you're no longer just "an HR fresher looking for a job."

You're a fresher who has **evidence of HR capability.**

Please note:

Course availability, batches, certificates and pricing can change.

For example, Great Learning currently lists multiple free HR courses, while its pages distinguish free learning access from paid certificates. NPTEL's current HR Analytics listing also shows that course schedules and enrollment windows are batch-specific.